

Dermatemys mawii

Central American river turtle



Length 20–26 in (50–65 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Critically endangered

Location S. Mexico to Central America



The webbed feet and streamlined shell of this olive-gray turtle are adaptations for swimming; it is almost helpless on land. Females have olive tops to their heads (yellowish to reddish brown in males), and very short tails. They lay 6–20 eggs in muddy river banks in summer and fall, burying them or covering them with decaying vegetation. While adults are herbivorous, the juveniles also eat mollusks, crustaceans, and, probably, fishes. This turtle is hunted by otters and humans.



Cuora flavomarginata

Yellow-marginated box turtle



Length 4–4¼ in (10–12 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Endangered

Location E. Asia (including Taiwan and Ryukyu Islands)



The yellow-marginated box turtle gets its name from a hinged plastron that allows it to be completely boxed in when withdrawn into its shell, and yellow stripes that run down its back and from each eye to the neck. It spends much of its time in rice paddies, ponds, and streams, but also basks and wanders on land. This turtle feeds on fishes, crustaceans, worms, and fruit. Nesting in soil or sand, females may lay several clutches of one or, occasionally, 2 eggs a year.



Cycllemys dentata

Asian leaf turtle



Length 6–9½ in (15–24 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Near threatened

Location S.E. Asia



The oval carapace of this turtle has a serrated edge near the tail, and is colored light to dark brown (sometimes mahogany) with faint dark markings. The plastron, which is hinged, is more boldly marked with lines radiating from the center of each scute. As with most turtles, males are smaller than females and have longer, thicker tails. The Asian leaf turtle is an omnivore,



feeding on invertebrates and tadpoles, as well as plants. Very active both on land and in water, it prefers shallow streams in either mountains or lowlands. When danger threatens, it may withdraw into its shell or dive to the bottom of the water and hide in the mud. The female digs a chamber in which she lays up to 5 clutches of 2–4 relatively large eggs each year; unusually, in this turtle, the plastron becomes flexible to allow eggs to be laid. Hatchlings are more aquatic than adults and have spines or points—which disappear with age—around the edge of the carapace, perhaps to deter predators.

Kinosternon flavescens

Yellow mud turtle



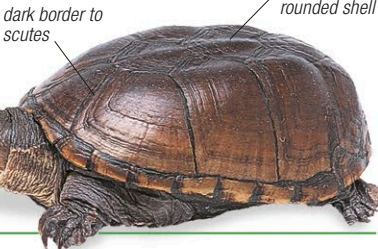
Length 4¾–6½ in (12–16 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Mainly aquatic
Status Least concern

Location S. Central USA, N. Mexico



In addition to withdrawing into its shell for defense, the yellow mud turtle can also release foul-smelling musk from 2 pairs of glands under its

carapace, and may occasionally bite. It has especially powerful jaws for crushing its prey, which includes snails, worms, insects, and tadpoles. Primarily diurnal, it spends most of its time in shallow, slow-moving bodies of water in grassland. In midsummer, it shelters from heat in muskrat dens or by burrowing under leaf litter. It hibernates in the cooler parts of its range.



Sternotherus odoratus

Stinkpot



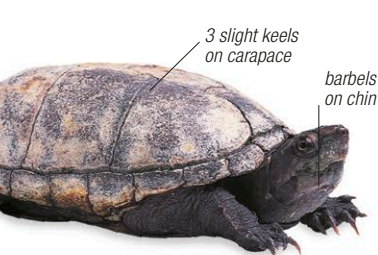
Length 3¼–5 in (8–13 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Mainly aquatic
Status Least concern

Location S. and E. USA



As a form of defense, this turtle expels a foul odor from its musk glands, hence the name “stinkpot.” It can also bite viciously. Rarely leaving quiet, shallow, muddy-bottomed waters, it is often covered in algae. It is

active by day, but may also hunt at night, and a pair of sensory barbels on the chin may help it to find food—mainly insects, mollusks, plant material, or carrion. It is eaten by bald eagles and red-shouldered hawks, alligators, and fishes such as the largemouth bass. Females nest under tree stumps or in the walls of muskrat lodges, laying 1–5 eggs at a time.



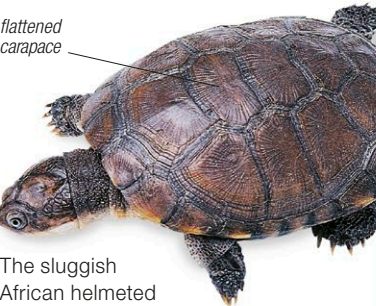
Pelomedusa subrufa

African helmeted turtle



Length 8–12½ in (20–32 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Semiaquatic
Status Not evaluated

Location Africa (south of Sahara)



The sluggish African helmeted turtle lives in rain pools and watering holes in Africa’s open country. During the rainy season, it wanders from pool to pool foraging for frogs, tadpoles, mollusks, invertebrates, and carrion. It may estivate in dry conditions by burying itself in mud. If threatened by crocodiles or other carnivores, it withdraws into its shell, helped by a hinged plastron, and may also discharge a strong-smelling musk and the contents of its cloaca.

Pelodiscus sinensis

Chinese soft-shelled turtle



Length 6–12 in (15–30 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Aquatic
Status Vulnerable

Location E. Asia



With its long snout and tubelike nostrils, the Chinese soft-shelled turtle can “snorkel” in shallow water. It also has webbed feet for swimming. When resting, it lies at the bottom, buried in sand or mud, lifting its head to breathe or snatch at prey. It forages at night, taking crustaceans, mollusks, insects, fishes, and amphibians. If threatened, it cannot withdraw completely into its shell, but it can give a vicious bite.

